Name:
Bun Kimly
Dy Seyha

Systematic Review of Encroachments on Basic Rights under the German Basic Law (Constitution)

My Prompts:
Cambodian students have prepared a text analyzing the Lüth decision (BVerfGE 7, 198) of the German Federal Constitutional Court and provided a comparative discussion with Cambodian law by following this temple:
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1. Brief explanation of the case and its legal problem
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...
Please use the attached research grid as a template.
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I. Introduction

1. Brief explanation of the case and its legal problem

The Lüth decision (BVerfGE 7, 198) of the German Federal Constitutional Court, issued on January 15, 1958, arose from a dispute involving Erich Lüth, the director of the Hamburg Press Office and

president of the Hamburg Press Club. In 1950, Lüth publicly called for a boycott of the film "Unsterbliche Geliebte" (Immortal Beloved), directed by Veit Harlan, a filmmaker who had produced propaganda films during the Nazi regime, including the antisemitic "Jud Süß." Harlan and the film's distributor sued Lüth under civil law provisions (§ 826 of the German Civil Code, BGB), claiming intentional infliction of damage contrary to good morals. Lower courts issued an injunction prohibiting Lüth from continuing his boycott calls, prioritizing private law protections for economic interests and personal honor over Lüth's expressions.

Lüth filed a constitutional complaint, arguing that the judicial decisions violated his fundamental right to freedom of expression. The core legal problem was whether state courts, in applying private law, must consider the influence of constitutional fundamental rights on disputes between private parties a concept later known as the indirect horizontal effect (mittelbare Drittwirkung) of basic rights and whether the injunction constituted an unjustified encroachment on freedom of expression.

2. Research Question

The question is whether the civil court injunctions prohibiting Erich Lüth from calling for a boycott of Veit Harlan's film violate his right to freedom of expression under Art. 5(1) of the Basic Law (Grundgesetz, GG), particularly in light of the radiating effect of fundamental rights on private law.

II. Body

Part 1: German Law

1. Most affected fundamental right: Art. 5(1) GG (Freedom of Expression)

Art. 5(1) GG states: "Every person shall have the right freely to express and disseminate his or her opinion in speech, writing and pictures and to inform himself or herself without hindrance from generally accessible sources."

a) Scope of Protection

1. Personal scope (persönlicher Schutzbereich):

The complainant, Erich Lüth, is a natural person and thus a rights-holder under Art. 5(1) GG. This right extends to all individuals, including German citizens and foreigners, as well as legal persons where applicable (pursuant to Art. 19(3) GG for domestic entities). Lüth qualifies as he acted in his personal capacity, expressing opinions on a matter of public concern.

2. Material scope (sachlicher Schutzbereich):

The substantive interest protected is the free formation, expression, and dissemination of opinions. Interpreted broadly, it encompasses value judgments on public issues like cultural accountability for Nazi-era actions. Lüth's boycott call qualifies as an opinion on a societal matter.

3. Result:

The scope of protection is engaged. Both personal and material elements are fulfilled Lüth's expression falls within the normative content of freedom of opinion.

b) Infringement / Encroachment

The judgments by the Hamburg Regional Court and Higher Regional Court restrict Lüth's exercise of Art. 5(1) GG by enjoining his speech. This constitutes a classical, targeted, and coercive interference by public authorities. The Court introduced the radiating effect, holding that fundamental rights influence the interpretation of private law norms, creating an indirect horizontal effect between private parties.

c) Justification

The justification of any interference with Art. 5(1) GG must pass through a structured, multi-step analysis. The diagram below illustrates how each layer statutory basis, constitutional limits, essential content guarantee, and the competing rights framework interacts within the overall justification review.

1. Statutory Basis

The interference rests on § 826 BGB (intentional infliction of damage contrary to good morals), which constitutes a formally valid statutory authorisation. However, pursuant to Art. 5(2) GG which provides the explicit limitation clauses for freedom of expression, this statutory basis must itself comply with constitutional requirements. Art. 5(2) GG permits limitations of freedom of expression through: (i) provisions of general laws (allgemeine Gesetze), (ii) statutory provisions for the protection of youth, and (iii) the right to personal honour.

Furthermore, § 826 BGB qualifies as a "general law" within the meaning of Art. 5(2) GG because it does not target a specific opinion or viewpoint but rather prohibits intentional immoral conduct generally. The Federal Constitutional Court confirmed this, but critically added that general laws must themselves be interpreted in light of the fundamental right they restrict the so-called wechselwirkende Auslegung (mutual interpretation principle).

2. Constitutional Limits Arising from Art. 5(2) GG

As depicted in the diagram, Art. 5(2) GG operates as both a gateway and a constraint. The limitation clauses in Art. 5(2) allow interference, but only if the interference itself remains constitutionally bounded. This creates a two-directional structure:

- **Art. 5(2) GG → "lim?" (Is there a valid limitation?):** The question at this stage is whether there is a competing interest. Here, Harlan's right to personal honour and economic freedom provides a constitutionally recognised basis for limiting Lüth's freedom of expression. This is confirmed: protection of personal honour is explicitly named in Art. 5(2) GG.
- **"con" (Constitutional limits on the limitation):** Even where a limitation is constitutionally permitted, it must not override the fundamental right's core guarantees. The limitation itself faces constitutional constraints, particularly Art. 19(2) GG and the principle of proportionality.

3. Competing Rights and Interests in the Balancing Framework

The diagram maps out two sets of competing constitutional interests that must be weighed against Art. 5(1) GG:

Lüth's Rights (Art. 5(1) GG)	Harlan's Competing Rights
Freedom of expression and opinion (Art. 5(1) GG) Human dignity as the foundation (Art. 1(1) GG) General freedom of action (Art. 2(1) GG)	Right to personal honour (Art. 5(2) GG) Economic freedom / professional activity (Art. 12 GG) General personality rights (Art. 2(1) in conjunction with Art. 1(1) GG)

The diagram's arrows from Art. 5(2) and the competing rights cluster (Art. 2(2), Art. 1+2) converge on a central balancing node signifying that no single right automatically prevails. The resolution requires proportional weighing of all affected interests under the constitutional value order (Wertordnung).

4. Essential Content Guarantee (Wesensgehaltsgarantie, Art. 19(2) GG)

As highlighted in the diagram's lower portion which represents the core Art. 19(2) GG provides an absolute floor: no limitation may touch the essential content (Wesensgehalt) of a fundamental right. For Art. 5(1) GG, the essential content comprises the freedom to form opinions and to participate in public discourse. An outright, blanket injunction prohibiting all boycott calls without any constitutional balancing risks eroding this essential core entirely.

This is particularly significant because the lower courts applied § 826 BGB without considering Art. 5(1) GG at all. By doing so, they failed to protect. The Federal Constitutional Court, therefore held that the injunction, in its absolute form, was constitutionally impermissible regardless of any subsequent proportionality analysis.

5. Formal Constitutionality

§ 826 BGB complies with formal constitutional requirements: it was enacted by the competent federal legislature, followed proper legislative procedures, and is sufficiently clear and certain in its prohibition of intentional immoral damage. No formal unconstitutionality arises.

6. Material Constitutionality and the Radiating Effect

Even if formally valid, § 826 BGB must be applied in a manner consistent with the constitutional value order. The Court's central holding illustrated by the diagram's central converging arrow, is that the judiciary, as a branch of state power bound by Art. 1(3) GG, must interpret and apply private law norms (such as the "good morals" standard in § 826 BGB) in a way that gives effect to fundamental rights.

The civil courts' failure to read § 826 BGB through the lens of Art. 5(1) GG constituted itself a violation of Lüth's fundamental right. The "good morals" clause is not a neutral private-law concept; it must be filled with constitutional content. A boycott call that serves a legitimate democratic purpose publicly criticising a filmmaker's Nazi-era collaboration, cannot be branded "immoral" without weighing the freedom of expression dimension. Material constitutionality therefore requires not only a valid statutory basis but also its constitutionally conforming application.

Result of Justification:
The interference with Art. 5(1) GG is based on a formally valid statutory foundation (§ 826 BGB as a "general law" under Art. 5(2) GG). However, material constitutionality requires that this provision be interpreted and applied in light of the radiating effect of fundamental rights. The lower courts' failure to conduct any constitutional balancing means the justification is incomplete. The interference therefore proceeds to the proportionality test, but already bears a fundamental constitutional defect arising from the courts' disregard of Art. 5(1) GG's objective dimension.

d) Proportionality Test (Verhältnismäßigkeit)

1. Legitimate aim: Protecting Harlan's economic interests and honour is constitutionally permissible under Art. 5(2) GG and Art. 2(1)/1(1) GG.

2. Suitability (Geeignetheit): The injunction is capable of advancing this aim by preventing further boycott calls.

3. Necessity (Erforderlichkeit): Less restrictive means exist. Courts could have balanced constitutional values within private disputes rather than imposing an outright prohibition. The necessity requirement is not met.

4. Proportionality in the strict sense: Weighing Lüth's freedom of expression given its heightened democratic importance in post-WWII Germany and the clear public interest in historical accountability, against Harlan's private economic interests, the interference is disproportionate. The Court held that freedom of opinion prevails in public debates unless overriding reasons exist. Lüth's non-violent, reasoned public critique does not meet the threshold for § 826 BGB liability.

2. Other Affected Fundamental Rights

- **Art. 1(1) GG (Human Dignity):** Implicitly engaged, as freedom of expression derives from and reinforces human dignity. The decision protects public discourse as foundational to individual dignity.
- **Art. 2(1) GG (General Freedom of Action):** Lüth's conduct could be characterised as general conduct, but Art. 5(1) GG operates as lex specialis. No independent analysis required.

Part 2: Comparison to Cambodian Law

Cambodian law provides a constitutional framework for freedom of expression under Art. 41 of the 1993 Constitution: "Khmer citizens shall have freedom of expression, press, publication and assembly. No one shall exercise this right to infringe upon the rights of others, to affect the good traditions of the society, to violate public law and order and national security."

1. Most affected fundamental right: Art. 41 (Freedom of Expression)

Unlike Germany's broad application to all persons, Art. 41 is limited to Khmer citizens, excluding foreigners and potentially legal persons. No equivalent to Germany's indirect horizontal effect is explicitly established in Cambodian jurisprudence.

a) Scope of Protection

Limited to Khmer citizens for the personal scope. The material scope protects expression, press, publication, and assembly but is narrower than Germany's, excluding expressions that infringe others' rights, traditions, public order, or national security from the outset.

b) Infringement

State actions restricting expression constitute interference attributable to public authorities. Cambodia recognises vertical effects (state vs. individual) but has no clear doctrine for horizontal effects in private disputes.

c) Justification

Requires statutory basis (e.g., Criminal Code Art. 502 on insults). Limits are explicit and broader than Germany's Art. 41 itself excludes expressions infringing others' rights, traditions, public order, or national security. There is no essential content guarantee equivalent to Art. 19(2) GG. In practice, restrictions on expression are frequently justified by appeals to public order or stability, without deep constitutional balancing.

d) Proportionality

Cambodia applies a loose proportionality influenced by ICCPR Art. 19(3), requiring legitimate aims, suitability, necessity, and balance. However, courts tend to defer to public order, making restrictions easier to justify than in Germany. A Lüth-like boycott might be treated as infringing "dignity of others" or "good traditions," leading to prohibition without rigorous proportional balancing.

ស៊ីន សុរម្យនា

Soromnear SIN (Mrs.)

Co-Principal

អាសយដ្ឋាន ២F TK Roundabout ផ្លូវលេខ ២៨៩
សង្កាត់បឹងកក់ទី២ ខណ្ឌទួលគោក រាជធានីភ្នំពេញ
Address : 2F. TK Roundabout, ST289
Sangkat Beoung Kak II, Khan Toul Kork
Phnom Penh

T: +855 (0)99 939 752
E: soromnear.sin@din-co.com
info@din-co.com